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Beauty Boot Camp

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(In a high school bathroom, a nervous girl, Margaret, approaches a mirror.)

Margaret: Hey James. There's something I need to ask you. Now, I know that you don't really know me, or have ever talked to me, or have probably heard even a faint whispering of my existence, but…. I think that…your face, is the…goodest, face…of all of the faces...and prom is next week, and--
(A pretty, primped girl walks up to the mirror next to her.)
Margaret: I'm going to die of embarrassment now.
Samantha: Are you okay? You look like your heart's about to explode out of your butt.
Margaret: No. Wait, yeah! I mean. I'm fine. I was just, uh…you know. Rehearsing a scene. In the bathroom mirror. It is for…scene, class. Bye.
(Margaret rushes to leave, but Sam pulls her back.)
Samantha: No, come back! Maybe I can help. I happen to be very knowledgeable when it comes to romance. And...everything in general.
Margaret: Thanks, but I really am a sane human being. That whole thing I was doing back there was just a joke. Ha! Got ya good. Look who's embarrassed now. You are. That's who.
Samantha: I like you. I'm Samantha.
Margaret: Marga--
Samantha: Oh my god, your name is Margaret? Gross.
Margaret: Uh...ha. You're joking, r--
Samantha: We're gonna call you Erika from now on, 'kay Erika? With a 'k'.
Erika: A...'K'?
Samantha: 'Kay. Next crisis…
Erika: Crisis?
Samantha: You need some lipstick…
Erika: Lips--
(Samantha forces lipstick on "Erika's" face.)
Samantha: A mist of perfume...
(She sprays it in Erika's face.)
Erika: Ow, my eyes!!
Samantha: And we'll finish the whole thing off with some powder!
Erika: No, stop! Please!

(She powders her up, Erika coughs. Samantha scans her up and down.)
Samantha: Alright...Good. Bad. Better. Huh. How does that even look like that?
Erika: Okay, WHAT THE HELL--
Samantha: Erika, with only two minutes of my help, you're already the second prettiest girl in this bathroom.
Erika: We're the only two in here...
Samantha: If you give me this whole week to mold you, change you, fix you, correct you, save you--
Erika: I get it--
Samantha: I will get James Masterson to be your prom date. Do we have a deal?
Erika: Hm...how do I know I can trust you?
Samantha: We met in a bathroom, what's not to trust?
Erika: Oh god, I'm desperate.

(In Samantha's bedroom, Erika brushes her hair.)

Samantha: Okay, lesson number seventy-one...no matter what a guy says, throw your head back and laugh like this...
(She performs a laugh that even Julia Roberts would consider 'too much'.)
Erika: I'm not doing that.
Samantha: Yes you are.
Erika: False.
Samantha: And you're also wearing this.
(She hands over a strand of cloth.)
Erika: Where's the rest of it?
Samantha: Okay, now that your outsides are looking a little better, let's repair your insides.
Erika: Man, if I had a nickel for every surgeon who's said that to me...I'd have thirty cents.
Samantha: Okay, bonus lesson? Don't try to be funny. You're welcome for that. Now. I'm going to list off random things that a boy may talk about, and I want you to respond like you're actually interested in them. Okay, first noun: off-road vehicles.
Erika: Roads? Who needs em!
Samantha: Fighting.
Erika: I would love to punch you in the mouth right now.
Samantha: Football.
Erika: Well I was the starting linebacker for the Chicago Bears in the 1950's don't ya know! Wanna toss around the pigskin young chap?
Sam: Maybe it's best if you just don't talk at all. Now, chin up...
(Sam slaps her chin.)
Erik: Ow!
Sam: Shoulders tall...and show us the biggest, prettiest smile you've got!
(Erika poses with a pained, hideous smile.)
Erika: Did it happen? Am I finally pretty, Sam?!
Samantha: (long pause) Okay time for your next lesson!

(The girls walk down the school hallway.)

Samantha: Okay, lesson number whatever. Walking down the school hallway is literally the most important way to attract guys because literally everyone in the school is watching you.
Erika: That is literally not possible.
Samantha: You looking pretty seemed impossible too. Now, watch how I walk...*(struts)* I'm bouncy, fun, confident, with just a hint of 'Hey how ya doin'?' thrown in for good measure. Got it?
Erika: Yes, walking. Because I didn't know how to do that previously. Thank you. You know, my cousin just learned to walk and he's fourteen. Months. How old are you?
Samantha: As I will eternally claim, I'm a wise twenty-one. Now, show me your best walk!
Erika: Okay...
(She slumps through the hallway.)
Samantha: Oh god you look like a depressed orangutan.

Erika: You're teaching me how to walk, this is so stupid!
Samantha: *(gasps*) Stupid?! You're calling my training...STUPID?!
Erika: Yes.
Samantha: I mean, how could you?!
Erika: Very easily.
Samantha: Fine. If you want to walk like you're filled with buffalo tranquilizer, be my guest. I guess it's time for more hands on training.
Erika: Cool, like what--
Samantha: Oh hello, boys.
(Samantha nudges Erika. She sees that they're now across from two bro's putting their backpack items into their lockers.)
Samantha: Don't you want to greet them, Erika?
Erika: What are you up to this fine day.
Boy 1: Nothing man! We're just putting stuff in our lockers!
Boy 2: Our lockers, man!
Boy 1: Totally, bro. I said that too!
Boy 2: Brooo.
Sam: *(does her weird laugh)* Oh my gosh, you guys are like so funny! Don't you want to tell them how funny they are, Erika?
Erika: Ah, yes. Yes that was quite humorous indeed. What would you gentlemen care to discuss next? Politics, perhaps? Literature? The existence of parallel universes? Hmmmm?
Boy 2: Whoa man. This reminds me of that time when you were really smart, but then you hit your head on that ceiling fan and then we've been best friends ever since. You remember that?
Boy 1: Mannnn! No, I don't…
Boy 2: Oh...
Erika: Concussion symptoms! What a delight.
Samantha: Yeah, it's definitely better when you don't talk. Do the smile I taught you.
Erika: And now, males, I am smiling at you...
(She does her weird smile from before. It's still just as weird. Maybe even weirder...)
Bro 2: This is uncomfortable.
Bro 1: Yeah dude.
Erika: And now if you'll excuse me, I'm going to walk away now and pretend this conversation never happened. Bye bye.
(Erika walks away, sending Sam into a tailspin.)
Samantha: What?! I'm sorry, uh, excuse us guys. We'll be back!
(She does her weird laugh as she heads after Erika.)

(In the next hallway, Sam catches up to Erika.)
Sam: Hey, you can't just walk out on a lesson like that! You agreed to listen to me, my help, my guidance, my show, me me me me me--
Erika: Why should I listen to you, Sam? Because you shoved lipstick on my face and gave me a sock to wear as a shirt?
Sam: No, you should listen because I've had more boyfriends than you've had cheeseburgers.
Erika: Oh. You'd be surprised. When are we actually going to do something...you know...helpful?

Sam: You say that like we've been wasting our time.
Erika: We talked to guys with the IQ of butter and you called me an orangutan. Seriously, I'll do whatever as long as it's, oh I don't know...actually useful!
Sam: Hm. Anything? In that case...I think I know just how to take your training to the next level...
Erika: Great, fine, cool, swag. Let's do it.

(We're now in Erika's bedroom. Sam preps a strip of wax on Erika's leg.)
Sam: ...two, three!
(Sam rips off the strip.)
Erika: ...OWWW YOU PSYCHO SPAWN OF SATAN AND...AND...SATAN'S WIFE!
Sam: Erika, I'm helping, will you let me help?
Erika: You...are ripping...all of the hair out--
Sam: Yes I am. Ready for the next one?
Erika: No, no, false--
(Sam rips her again.)
Erika: SON OF A BISCUIT! What is wrong with you?!
Sam: Nothing. That's why I'm the one helping and not the other way around. Now let's hurry to jazzercise class!
Erika: Whoa, what--

(Sam whisks Erika away and we're suddenly in an aerobics studio, with girls dancing along to a routine, Erika failing with fatigue.)
Erika: Oh please. Make my life stop. No more life please.
Sam: Suck it up, we've got another stop to make!
Erika: What?! Tomorrow, right--
Sam: Right now!

(Sam yanks her away. They stand in front of James Masterson's house.)
Erika: *(panting)* I...am...very….much...not...a fan...of you.
Sam: Well that's about to change. Guess where we are!
Erika: Please tell me it's ice cream. Ice cream?! Is that you?!
Sam: We...are outside...of James Masterson's house!
Erika: What?! I'm going to kill you!
Sam: Yes!
Erika: No! Murder! I can't let him see me like this! I look like I was just birthed out of a sweaty sheep!
Sam: Erika...I've trained you. Don't you trust my training?
Erika: No.
Sam: Don't you trust me?
Erika: Not at all.
Sam: Well, I believe in you.
Erika: You really shouldn't.
Sam: Too late, here you go…

(Sam shoves Erika up to the door. Erika's face turns to shock as she looks up.)

Erika: H-...Hi, James…
(James, bulky with muscle, steps out.)
James: Uh, hello...sweaty girl?
Erika: Yeah, that. I was just...uh...sweating. Listen, James. I know you don't really know me, but I am really awesome. And I'm just a really great, awesome person that you should get to know. You know? And so, if you would be so kind as to go to prom with me...
James: Whoa whoa whoa hold up, stop. Stop right there.
Erika: Okay.
James: Stop.
Erika: I'm stopping.
James: Are you stopped?
Erika: Yes.
James: Good. Now look, I don't even know who you are, why the hell would I go to a sweaty prom with you? I mean you could be like...a murderer? Or like, somebody who runs around stealing cheese out of people's houses!
Erika: I would nev--well…
James: Look. You made my porch wet and you smell like my grandma after she goes up the stairs. Please leave. I have a taser.
Erika: Wow. I really should've spoken to you before I fell in love, alright!
James: Taser!
Erika: Got it. Thanks James.

(Erika walks away. Sam meets her at the sidewalk.)
Sam: Well that went well...
Erika: What. The poo. Was that?! James Masterson? More like...James...Masterson-not! He is...not, the son of a master--Look, Sam. I tried your way. I tried being a beautiful robot of beauty and I'm just not, okay?! Listening to you has just led me to the front yard of a very attractive psychopath who threatened to tase me.
Sam: Hey, do you think *I'm* happy?! I was already a beautiful robot of beauty and I wasted my week helping you, so now I don't even have a date for prom! Like some loser who's good at math or something.
Erika: Wait...the two of us need dates? Sam. I think we only have one option…
Sam: What did I say about math...
Erika: Sam, I think we have to...go...to--
Sam: Oh god, this is gonna be the worst prom ever, isn't it?
Erika: Quite possibly.

(Sam and Erika slow-dance at the prom, cry-singing along to the music.)

Erika + Sam: Allll byyyy myyyyself….
Erika: You look beautiful tonight, Sam.
Sam: You know what, Erika? You do too. And I'm not just saying that as a joke that I'll secretly laugh at on the inside and also joke about with my friends afterwards.
Erika: Huh. Great, I guess...Look, I'm getting a little dehydrated. You want some punch?

Sam: Yes if it's fat-free.
Erika: Okay, so no punch.

(Erika walks over to the punch table. James sees her and approaches.)
James: Whoa, hottie alert! Hey guys, there's a hot girl over here!
Erika: Uh...where? James? Do you mean--
James: You are like, super hot, girl. You wanna date me? Who am I kidding, of course you--
Erika: Uh, no, I'm good.
James: ...WHAT. Oh, wait, it's a joke. Haha, funny joke hot girl! Now you'll be my girlfriend and kiss me on the face!
Erika: You know, if you had asked me that two days ago I would've drooled, cried, said yes, and then celebrated by screaming for joy around my neighborhood and telling all of my parent's friends. But...you know, you...YOU THREATENED TO TASE ME!
James: To be fair, you were sweating a lot…
Erika: Look, as I've heard other girls say, 'if you're not interested when I'm at my worst, don't expect to get me at my best'. Which isn't even now, by the way, I can crank this hotness up to 11.
James: Whoa...
Erika: Now imagine that as I walk away.
James: *(imagining)* Aw, man, it's so amazing!

(Erika walks back onto the dance-floor. Sam rushes up to her.)
Sam: Oh my god oh my god oh my god, did James Masterson just ask you to dance?!
Erika: Hm. He said a lot of words, but 'dance' wasn't one of them. Look, Sam, I appreciate everything you've done for me, but the truth is it's stupid to care this much about how you look. I mean, obsessing over every physical detail, playing whack-a-mole with your flaws...all it does is make you dislike yourself. And I like liking myself. So, yeah.
Sam: *(smiles, applauds)* Bravo. Everybody, bravo!
Erika: Uh, Sam, what are you doing?
Sam: With that final lesson, you have officially graduated from Beauty Bootcamp!
Erika: Hoooooow….?
Samantha: When I first saw you in that bathroom talking to yourself like a really weird weirdo, it didn't make me want to change how you looked. It made me want to change how you felt. About yourself. No guy is ever worth making you hate yourself, ever. Okay maybe Brad Pitt, but that's it. So...May I have this dance, Erica? I mean--Margaret?
Margaret: Why yes, Samantha. I mean—Samantha...
(They slow-dance, teetering gently to the music.)
Sam + Margaret: Alllll byyyy myyyselfffffff
Sam: You were a little flat there…
Margaret: Shut it.